

The Age Crisis Reversal: AI Favors Seniority

Before AI

The "35-Age Crisis"

Young workers: cheap, overwork, replaceable → preferred

Senior workers: expensive, hard to manage → cut at 35

Company logic: 3 juniors = 1 senior, but cheaper



After AI

The "25-Age Crisis"

Senior+AI: 1 person output = 1 senior + 3 juniors → more needed

Junior workers: AI does their work → can't get in

Company logic: 1 senior+AI > 1 senior+3 juniors

Harvard Study (2025): 62M workers · 285k companies

AI-adopting firms: entry-level hiring ↓ 7.7-10% (within 6 quarters) · Senior roles: nearly unchanged

Entry-Level Collapse

US big tech new grad hiring



US entry-level job postings



Fortune 500 internships (tech)



UK tech graduate positions



China graduate job postings



China Youth Unemployment

Age 16-24: 18.9% (Aug 2025)

2025 graduates: 12.22M (record) · Hiring ↓ 22%

The Paradox

AI boosts junior productivity more (27-39% vs 8-13%)

The Broken Career Ladder

Senior promoted/leaves → Mid fills up → Junior fills up → ~~New hire enters~~ ← AI cuts this link

No entry-level jobs = no ticket in = never becoming "experienced" · A generation's career may end before it begins

The crisis didn't disappear — it shifted down a decade. From "fired at 35" to "can't get in at 25."